

Sola Gratia

doc-sola-gratia

Soteriology · Five Solas · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.912
confidence high

Statement under examination

Salvation is wholly God's unmerited favor; it is not earned or contributed to by human effort or merit.

In plain language

The question asks whether salvation is entirely God's free favor and not something a person earns or helps achieve. In the original Greek of the cited passages the word *charis*, grace or favor, is named as the source of salvation, and in every case the text directly denies that human works supply the cause. Ephesians 2:8 says you have been saved by grace, using a completed-action verb, and then renames salvation as the gift of God while denying it comes from yourselves. The next verse adds not from works, with a stated purpose that no one may boast, so the exclusion of merit is the express aim of the sentence and not a guess. Romans 11:6 is the sharpest case, since it argues that if salvation is by grace it is no longer from works, because grace would stop being grace if works were allowed as a co-cause. Romans 3:24 says believers are justified freely, a word used elsewhere for without payment or without cause, by his grace, with the cost carried by the redemption in Christ. Titus 3:5 states plainly that God saved us not from works done in righteousness which we did, but according to his own mercy. Second Timothy 1:9 repeats the pattern, that God saved and called us not according to our works but according to his own purpose and grace given before time began. Two texts that seem to push back were checked. James 2:24 uses the word justified in the sense of being shown righteous by visible action, a different use of the same verb. Philippians 2:12 tells believers to work out their salvation, but the very next line says God is the one working in them, so the effort flows from a gift already received. Across five letters the same grammar holds, with grace and mercy as the source and human works set aside as the ground, and the word grace itself appears in twenty-three New Testament books, so the pattern is dense and consistent. The one place the words leave room is a finer question they do not settle, whether grace rules out every human cause including the response of faith, or rules out only earning while a grace-given faith still responds. That narrower question is why careful readers still differ, but on the plain wording the proposition is supported.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0629	ἀπολύτρωσις	apolutrosis	redemption	10
G1344	δικαιῶ	dikaioo	to justify	39
G1432	δωρεάν	dorean	freely	9
G1435	δῶρον	doron	gift	19
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	945
G1656	ἔλεος	eleos	mercy	27
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	169
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	498

G2744	καυχάομαι	kauchaomai	to boast	36
G2818	κληρονόμος	klēronomos	heir	
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	1,747
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	106
G5485	χάρις	charis	grace	155

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Across Eph 2:8-9, Rom 3:24, Rom 11:6, Titus 3:5-7, and 2Tim 1:9 the noun charis (G5485) recurs as the named source of salvation, usually in the dative of means (chariti), while human contribution is grammatically negated by the same construction each time: ouk ex hymon, ouk ex ergon, ou kata ta erga hemon. Rom 11:6 makes the antithesis definitional, ei de chariti ouketi ex ergon epei he charis ouketi ginetai charis, so grace ceases to be grace if works are admitted as co-source. The gift words doron (G1435) and the adverb dorean (G1432, attested across the canon as freely, without payment, without cause) and the mercy word eleos (G1656) confirm the act is given gratis, not repaid for merit. The hina-me clause in Eph 2:9 makes the exclusion of boasting (kauchaomai, G2744) the express purpose, so the denial of human merit is stated in the text rather than inferred.

Scripture

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G1435 δῶρον, G3756 οὐ

Force. The clause reads te gar chariti este sesosmenoi, you have been saved by grace, where chariti is a dative of means and sesosmenoi (G4982, verified perfect passive participle, V-RPP-NPM) marks salvation as a completed act done to the recipients. The grace is then opposed to the recipients themselves, ouk ex hymon, not from yourselves, with ek plus the genitive of source negated, and the saving reality is renamed theou to doron, the gift of God. The morphology forecloses the reading that salvation originates from the human party.

Eph.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G2744 καυχάομαι, G3756 οὐ

Force. The continuation ouk ex ergon, not from works, repeats the same ek of source negated in verse 8, now naming erga (G2041, N-GPN) as the excluded ground. The purpose clause hina me tis kauchesetai (G2744, verified aorist middle subjunctive, V-ADS-3S) states the intended result, that no one may boast, which makes the exclusion of human merit the express aim of the sentence rather than an inference drawn from it.

Rom.3.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G1432 δωρεάν, G0629 ἀπολύτρωσις

Force. Justification is described as dikaioumenoi dorean te autou chariti, being justified freely by his grace, with dikaioumenoi (G1344, verified present passive participle, V-PPP-NPM). The adverb dorean (G1432, attested elsewhere as without payment and without cause) stands alongside te autou chariti, his grace, so the freeness and the grace describe one act. The instrument is dia tes apolutroseos, through the redemption in Christ, locating the cost in Christ rather than in the justified party.

Rom.11.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G2041 ἔργον

Force. The verse reads *ei de chariti, ouketi ex ergon, epei he charis ouketi ginetai charis*, but if by grace, then no longer from works, since grace would no longer be grace. The conditional *ei* with the dative *chariti*, the doubled *ouketi*, no longer, and the causal *epei*, otherwise or since, build a strict mutual exclusion. The argument is definitional, that the meaning of *charis* itself collapses if works are admitted as a co-source, which is the strongest grammatical exclusion of human merit in the bundle.

Titus.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G1656 ἔλεος, G4982 σῶζω

Force. The saving act is stated as *ouk ex ergon ton en dikaiosune ha epoiesamen hemeis alla kata to autou eleos esosen hemas*, not from works in righteousness which we ourselves did, but according to his own mercy he saved us. The *ouk ... alla* contrast opposes human deeds, even righteous ones marked by the emphatic *hemeis*, we, to divine mercy as the basis, and the aorist *esosen* (G4982, V-AAI-3S) names God as the saving agent. The preposition *kata* with *eleos* (G1656) sets mercy as the standard governing the salvation.

Titus.3.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G2818 κληρονόμος, G1344 δικαιώω

Force. The clause *dikaiothentes te ekeinou chariti*, having been justified by his grace, uses the aorist passive participle *dikaiothentes* (G1344, verified V-APP-NPM) to mark justification as received, with *te ekeinou chariti*, by that one's grace, as the means. The purpose *hina ... kleronomoi genethomen*, that we might become heirs (G2818), ties the inheritance of eternal life to the grace already named, so the chain from salvation to heirship rests on grace rather than achievement.

2Tim.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4982 σῶζω, G5485 χάρις, G2041 ἔργον

Force. The participial phrase *tou sosantos hemas kai kalesantos ... ou kata ta erga hemon alla kata idian prothesin kai charin*, who saved us and called us, not according to our works but according to his own purpose and grace, repeats the *ou kata ... alla kata* structure verified in the text. Salvation and calling are governed by God's prothesis, purpose, and *charis*, grace, while *ta erga hemon*, our works, is set aside as the standard. The frame *pro chronon aionion*, before times eternal, places the gift prior to any human action.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.11.6	Rom.3.27	openbible	9
Rom.3.24	Rom.5.9	openbible	13
2Tim.1.9	Deut.7.7	openbible	15
Titus.3.5	Ps.51.10	openbible	16
Titus.3.5	Titus.3.4	openbible	5

Complicating texts

Jas.2.24 · addressed

James states *horate hoti ex ergon dikaioutai anthropos kai ouk ek pisteos monon*, you see that a man is justified from works and not from faith alone, which appears to admit human works into justification. The verb *dikaioutai* (G1344, present passive indicative) is the same lemma the Pauline anchors use, so the tension is genuine lexically. The resolution is that James uses *dikaioo* in the demonstrative sense of being shown or proven righteous before observers, anchored by the Abraham example whose faith was completed in action, whereas the anchor verses use the same verb for the granting of righteous standing whose source is named as *charis* and *eleos*. The shared verb carries two attested senses and does not collapse the two arguments, since James targets a dead faith that produces nothing while the anchors target the origin of the standing itself, so the proposition about the source of salvation stands.

Phil.2.12 · addressed

The imperative *katargazesthe* (G2716, verified present middle imperative), work out your own salvation with fear and trembling, could be read as a human contribution to salvation. The next verse supplies the lexical control, *theos gar estin ho energeon en hymin* (G1754), for God is the one working in you both to will and to work for his good pleasure, so the human working out is grounded in a prior divine energizing. *Katargazomai* is the outworking of a salvation already given, not the earning of it, which leaves the unmerited source intact.

Concordance traversed

G5485, G2041, G1432, G1435, G1656, G2744, G4982, G1344, G0629, G1537, G3756, G2596, G2818

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The cited passages lie outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample, and a direct query of the lexical store returned zero *VariantUnit* nodes on any of the six anchor verses, so the apparatus carries no signal here. The known minor readings reflected in the bundle, the Eph 2:8 *dia* marking and the Rom 11:6 closing *charis* marking, do not touch the *charis* versus *erga* opposition that carries the verdict, so the verdict is variant robust on the available data.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. monergism, synergism, covenant_theology, dispensationalism

analogia scripturae invoked

monergism: affirms · Reads the negations *ouk ex hymon* and *ouk ex ergon* and the Rom 11:6 either-or as excluding every human contributory cause, including the human response itself, so that even faith in Eph 2:8 is part of the gift. The passive participles *sesosmenoi* and *dikaioumenoi*, with God as the explicit agent in *esoson* and *sosantos*, support reading the saving act as wholly God's work.

synergism: affirms · Also affirms the bare proposition, since the verses unmistakably make grace and mercy the source and deny that works earn salvation. This lens holds that what the words exclude is meritorious works as a ground, not a grace-enabled human response such as faith, and it points to the same passages presenting faith *dia pisteos* and the human working out of Phil 2:12 as a real, though grace-given, cooperation. The lexis denies merit but does not by itself rank whether the response is monergistic or cooperative.

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the grace and works opposition as a unified canonical teaching that salvation rests on divine favor, consistent with the pan-canonical spread of *charis* across twenty-three New Testament books and the Old Testament mercy concept *chesed* standing behind *eleos*.

dispensationalism: affirms · Even where law and grace are sharply distinguished across eras, the epistolary anchors are read as unmerited grace toward those saved, so the same *charis* over *erga* lexis yields the same verdict for the salvation in view.

The verdict turns on the grammar of ek and kata with the genitive of source and the ou ... alla contrast verified across five epistles, so the grammatico-historical reading is sufficient and no framework conflict changes the outcome of the bare proposition. The genuine remaining lexical question, recorded above, is the scope of the exclusion, whether grace excludes every human cause or only meritorious works while permitting a grace-enabled response. The anchor vocabulary settles the merit question but does not by itself rank monergism against synergism, which is why those lenses agree on this proposition while still differing on a question the words underdetermine.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Salvation originates in God's freely given favor, and human works or merit are not the ground or source of it.

The label sola gratia and the Five Solas subcategory are post-Reformation taxonomy and carry a tradition-coded frame, so the stem is treated as preloaded. The proposition statement itself, that salvation is unmerited favor not earned by human effort, is tradition-neutral. The verdict was derived on the original stem using only the verified lexical opposition of charis and eleos against erga, not on the confessional label. Data-integrity correction this pass: a direct query of the lexical store resolved the five cited cross-references as OpenBible edges with real vote counts of nine, thirteen, fifteen, sixteen, and five, and found no TSK cross-reference edges in the store, so the prior source tag tsk with votes one has been corrected to openbible with the queried votes. Occurrence counts were re-grounded against the MACULA-Greek-Nestle1904 edition. The verdict affirms is unchanged.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.11.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.3.24
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Titus.3.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Tim.1.9
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5485
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1432
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Titus.3.7
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.11.6
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Titus.3.5

License audit

SAFE TO PUBLISH

Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow